

8, Why Observe Byzantium and the Necessity of Considering Commercial Factors

Why do I append a section narrating the history of Byzantium? There are four reasons.

First, the **Near East** (近东) (*I use this term here primarily out of respect for the subject of this narrative, Byzantium*), as the cradle of human civilization, served as the epicenter of human civilization for fully 70% of human history. Byzantium was a state that ruled this region for a prolonged period and exerted a monumental impact; therefore, I deem it absolutely necessary to narrate its history.

Second, I have previously indicated that Byzantium, as the remnant of a **classical empire**, still retained the bureaucratic system of the classical period (*though inevitably with some mutations*) during an era when its peripheries had already been universally **feudalized**. Ultimately, this ancient relic was unexceptionally eliminated by history due to the obsolescence of its social system. Readers will naturally wonder: *Are there any similarities between the continuous bureaucratic system of the Byzantine Empire and the **restoration-bureaucratic system** established and consolidated in China during the period of Byzantine revival? And are there any clearly distinguishable differences?* I believe I need to answer these two questions.

Third, by narrating the historical issues of Byzantium, I am laying the groundwork in advance for the writing of the next chapter, introducing a corrective factor that has not been emphasized previously: **commercial and trade networks**.

Fourth, although I personally obviously cannot harbor much affection for Byzantium—because I am acutely aware that if a classical state like Byzantium never perished, or if, for some reason, it conquered vast territories like the **restoration-bureaucratic** China, it would only bring unprecedented disaster. Considering its geographical proximity to Europe, the overarching situation of human civilization would have become exceedingly grim.

However, I must also admit that the Fall of Constantinople in 1453 is absolutely one of the most unforgettable moments in history; this is a consensus even within China. In the final dozens of days of the siege, the monarch and the people of this city, the militia and the reinforcements, and even the Turks outside the walls collectively forged what Stefan Zweig would call a "**stellar moment of humanity**" (人类群星闪耀的时刻), remembered by the world for over 500 years.

For a Chinese person like myself, who intimately understands the destiny of his own country, such a spectacle obviously possesses an "**apocalyptic**" (启示录) significance. It constantly reminds us that even the greatest of nations cannot escape the day of its demise.

What moves me about Byzantium is that, even though it similarly embarked on a "deviant path" (*of course, we will subsequently see that Byzantium's trajectory was obviously far from a true deviant path; it at least conformed to the principles revealed by sociology*), and even though its actions were certainly not devoid of despicable aspects in the past, **the brilliance of its final moment at least granted the entire nation a decent and dignified end**.

Yet, I believe that even such a dignified exit is something utterly impossible for China to pursue! This inevitably makes my personal attitude toward Byzantium extremely complex, and thus I am willing to expend ink on it here. (*Aside from this chapter, there are a few remaining commentaries regarding Byzantium's feudalization process in Chapter XII, Section 23*).

Although I intend to explicitly lay out my theory on historical periodization in the next chapter, readers who have followed along from the beginning likely already have a solid grasp of my perspectives. An astute reader will inevitably raise the following question:

If the classical period is viewed as the transition between a **slavery society** (*readers, please do not forget that under the Chinese context, I have no better alternative but to use this term*) and a **feudal society**, then there is absolutely no rational justification for the **Near East** to have experienced such an exceedingly protracted classical society!

Suppose we view the **Achaemenid Empire** (阿契美尼德王朝), which rose in the 6th century BC, as the first great **classical empire** (*it undeniably already possessed the characteristics of a classical empire*), and view Byzantium as its continuous classical successor. In that case, regions like **Anatolia** (安纳托利亚) experienced a classical period stretching for an astonishing 15 centuries! And across the entire **Fertile Crescent** (新月沃土), the classical period exceeded a millennium.

This defies all logic.

Solely to resolve this glaring chronological anomaly, a monumental corrective factor must be introduced. I believe this corrective factor is **commercial and trade networks**.

I have long noticed that there indeed exist certain regimes built upon a **social being** (社会存在) ostensibly more backward than the classical period, yet they exhibited a substantial array of **classical characteristics**—such as vast territorial expanse, formidable monarchical power, prosperous urban centers, a developed commodity economy, ideological openness, and academic flourishing.

First, this is because highly developed international trade created massive volumes of circulation. The influx of advanced technology and culture from afar enabled the regions along these trade routes to accumulate staggering wealth. Consequently, relatively backward regions situated within the trade network had the opportunity to rapidly elevate their civilizational level, granting them the capacity to sustain a stratum of non-productive members of society (脱产的社会成员).

Second, although agriculture is undeniably the indisputable bedrock for all pre-industrial large states, for the ruling class of the state, *commerce* is exceptionally crucial. The reason is incredibly simple: For a state with vast territorial expanses—even a state with a bureaucratic system as highly developed as China's—it is exceedingly difficult for the monarch to accurately grasp the situation in regions distant from the capital. Because no matter what, the administrative capacity of a state can never exceed the absolute limit sustainable by its socio-economic baseline.

In eras where monetary circulation was insufficiently developed, many states still had to collect taxes in kind, primarily grain. The mere fact that grain could rot was highly detrimental to a massive state!

Commerce, however, is entirely different. Trade—especially the highly lucrative international luxury trade—inevitably concentrated in a minority of commercial cities boasting superior geographical locations. To minimize costs, the primary participants in this trade inevitably chose to reside concentrically. **This perfectly facilitated management and taxation by the central government!**

Therefore, international trade could drastically alter the balance of power between the center and the localities. Even though the central government lacked the capacity to pervasively control the

boundless rural expanse, maintaining concentrated control over a few major cities was never a problem. In this manner, the power of the central government, headed by the monarch, was massively amplified.

Finally, if a state's economy is highly dependent on trade, this could introduce **merchants and the burgher class** (市民阶层) capable of playing a pivotal role in politics.

Originally, when conceptualizing the classical period, we merely emphasized the process of transitioning ruling power between **slave-owning aristocrats** and **feudal landlords**. But once merchants and burghers also enter politics as a substantial force, they are entirely capable of counterbalancing one side while the other is practically inactive. This implies that a classical state can absolutely emerge earlier than the transitional period (早产), just as it can continue to survive for a period after the transitional period has concluded (延寿).

Proceeding this way indeed yields numerous benefits for conceptualizing historical issues. For example, we can now explicitly differentiate Byzantium from China, even though the bureaucratic systems of both nations persisted for an incredibly long time during the era of **feudalization**.

However, what we simultaneously cannot ignore is that once we loosen the definitional constraints of classical states and classical societies, a new problem emerges: *Just how "premature" can a massive state be while still qualifying as a classical state?* How do we accurately differentiate between a prematurely matured classical state and a slavery state that merely became exceptionally bloated due to commercial interests? How do we accurately judge whether trade was the primary influence, or if a leader possessing **Charismatic authority** simply played the core role?

Questions like these are only easy to answer in pure theory. After all, one can effortlessly toss out tautological assertions: *Only a regime that has undergone a qualitative change can be deemed a premature classical state; those with mere quantitative changes are simply bloated early (slavery) states.*

But regarding the exact threshold that constitutes a "qualitative change," obviously, different people are highly unlikely to share a unanimous consensus. One could clearly stipulate that a regime possessing certain characteristics simultaneously (*creating a massive checklist encompassing every conceivable trait of a classical empire*) is definitively a classical state, and declare that those completely lacking these traits are definitely not. Yet, establishing a universally accepted classification for states possessing only *some* of these traits remains fundamentally elusive.

Therefore, my stance is this: Although commercial trade is indeed a necessary corrective factor, unless we are absolutely forced to introduce it for explanation, we should not treat it as a primary cause!

I state this with another consideration in mind: **While commercial and trade factors can indeed stretch classical society in both directions along the timeline, this is fundamentally insufficient to alter the essential historical position of the classical period!**

For regions that prematurely rushed into classical society, lingering too long in the classical period failed to bring sustained, substantial social progress to the local area. Instead, as demonstrated by Persia, they sank into a sort of stagnation, ultimately turning into the relatively backward party.

For regions that perpetuated classical society into the era of **feudalization**, an ancient empire standing out like a crane among a flock of fragmented feudal regimes (鹤立鸡群的老大帝国) still

fundamentally could not bypass the feudal stage to stride into modern society! The achievements of a classical empire are indeed mesmerizing, but the factors decisively critical to the genesis of modern civilization must, in the end, pass through the crucible of a **feudal society** to emerge. Byzantium's history amply proves this point.

Given the right circumstances, even an exceptionally fleeting classical society is sufficient to realize a successful institutional transition and guide the state toward modernization; Japan is precisely such an example.

Therefore, no matter to what extent commerce and trade prolonged the classical period, the core characteristic of classical society as a **"transition"** remains utterly unaltered. No matter how protracted the classical period may be, its utility remains strictly limited; **it can never supplant the historical mandate of a feudal society!**

8, 为什么要观察拜占庭以及考虑商贸因素的必要性

为什么我要追加叙述一段拜占庭呢？这有四个方面的原因，首先近东（因为这一段主角是拜占庭，这主要是为了尊敬叙述对象）作为人类文明的起源地，作为人类文明的中心的时长达到了人类文明史的七成，而拜占庭又是在这个地区曾经长期统治并产生重大影响的国家，因此我认为对其有叙述的必要。其次，我之前已经表明拜占庭作为古典帝国的残留，在周边已经普遍封建化的时期仍然保有古典时期的官僚体制（当然必然也有所变化），最终这个老古董毫不例外地因为其社会体制的陈旧被历史淘汰。那么读者当然会想，拜占庭帝国延续的官僚制度跟中国在拜占庭帝国复兴时期，建立并巩固的复辟官僚制度有什么相似性吗，又有什么可以明显区分的差别吗？我认为我需要对这两点进行回答。第三，借着叙述拜占庭的历史问题，我也为下一章的书写提前做一些铺垫，引入之前没有强调过的修正因素，也就是商业和贸易网络。第四，虽然我本人显然不可能对拜占庭有太多好感，因为我很清楚如果像拜占庭这样的古典国家永远不灭亡，甚至因为某些原因像复辟的官僚中国一样征服了广大地区，那么它带来的只能是空前的灾难，考虑到其地理位置与欧洲的接近，整个人类文明的形势都会变得极不乐观。

但是我也不得不承认，君士坦丁堡在 1453 年的陷落绝对是历史上最令人难以忘怀的瞬间，这一点哪怕在中国大家也是有共识的。在最后几十天的围城战中，这座城市的君主和人民，民兵和援军，甚至是包括城外的土耳其人在内共同创造了堪称“人类群星闪耀”的时刻，500 多年来为世人所铭记。对于像我这样深知自己国家命运的中国人来说，这种场面显然具有“启示录”一样的意义，它时时刻刻提醒我们即使是最伟大的国家也不可能没有消亡的一天。拜占庭能够打动我的是，哪怕他一样走上了“邪路”（当然我们随后就会看到，拜占庭的历程跟真正的邪路显然相去甚远，它至少符合社会学所揭示的原理），哪怕它的行为曾经也少不了可鄙之处，但是最后一刻的光芒至少让整个国家有了体面的结局。然而就是这样一个体面的退场，我认为对于中国而言都是完全难以追求的，这必然使得我本人对拜占庭的态度极为复杂，因此也愿意在此着墨。除了本章之外，还有余下的一些关于拜占庭封建化进程的评论在第十二章第二十三节。

虽然我打算到下一章才明确给出对于历史分期的理论，但是读者如果从头看到这里想必也已经对于我的看法心中有数了，聪明的读者一定会产生这样一个疑问：如果把古典时期视为奴隶制阶级社会（还请读者不要忘记，在中国这种语境下我也是没有什么好的办法替换这个词）和封建阶级社会的交替，那么近东确实不存在理由经历了如此漫长的古典社会。假设我们把公元前六世纪崛起的阿契美尼德王朝（Achaemenid）视为第一个伟大的古典帝国（它当然已经存在古典帝国的特征），而把拜占庭视为延续的古典帝国的话那么像安纳托利亚这样的地区甚至经历了长达 15 个世纪的古典时期，而在整个新月沃土古典时期也超过了一千年，这件事情是很没有道理的。单单为了解决这个问题，就必须加入一个重大修正，我认为这个修正就是商业和贸易网络。

我早就注意到的确存在这样一些政权，他们建立在明显要比古典时期落后的社会存在上，但是却展现出了相当多的古典特征，例如领土庞大，君权强盛，城市繁荣，商品经济发达，思想开放，学术繁荣等等。这是首先是因为发达的国际贸易创造了规模巨大的流通，来自远方的先进技术文化传入，使得其经过的地区积累财富。于是相对落后的地区在贸易网络中有机会迅速提升其文明程度，更有能力供养一批脱产的社会成员。其次虽然对所有前工业时期的大国来说农业都是无可争议的基石，但是对于国家的

统治阶级来说，商业却极其重要。原因是非常简单的，对于一个幅员辽阔的国家，即使像中国官僚系统如此发达的国家，君主也很难准确了解距离远离首都地区的情况，因为无论如何这个国家的行政能力也不可能超出他的社会经济水平所能支撑的极限。在货币流通还不足够发达的时期，很多国家还需要征收以粮食为主的实物税，单单粮食可能腐坏这一点对于一个大国来说就是非常不利的。而商业不同，贸易特别是利润巨大的国际奢侈品贸易必然集中在地理位置优越的少数商业城市，而贸易的主要参与者为了降低成本必然选择集中居住，这就方便了中央政府进行管理和征税。因此国际贸易能够显著改变中央与地方的力量对比，因为中央政府虽然没有能力去无孔不入地控制辽阔无边的农村，但是重点管理几个大城市总是没问题的，这样一来以君主为首的中央政府的权力就扩大了。

最后，如果一个国家的经济非常依赖于贸易的话，那么这可能引入在政治中能够扮演重要角色的商人和市民阶层。原本在考虑古典时期的时候，我们只是强调奴隶主贵族和封建地主两者的统治权产生更迭这一过程，但是一旦商人和市民也作为可观的势力参与到政治中，那么它完全可能在前两者之一基本不起作用的同时制衡另外一方。这就是说，古典国家完全可以在比过渡期要早的时间出现，同样也可能在过渡期结束之后仍能存续一段时间。这样做确实会为考虑问题带来很多好处，例如，我们现在可以明确地把拜占庭和中国相区别，尽管两国的官僚体制在封建化时期都仍然存在了很久。可是我们同样也不能忽视的是，一旦放宽了对古典国家和古典社会定义的限制，那么早产到何种程度的大国能够算古典国家就成为新的问题，如何准确区别一个早熟的古典国家和一个因为商业利益而变得十分庞大的奴隶制国家呢，如何准确判断究竟是贸易起到了主要影响还是干脆只是一个卡里斯玛式领袖起到了核心作用？像这样的疑问只有在理论上才是容易回答的，毕竟人们可以很容易给出废话一样的论断：只有产生质变的政权才能视为早熟古典国家，而只有量变的就都是一个过于庞大的早期（奴隶制）国家罢了。但是关于什么程度才能算得上是质变，显然不同的人就不太可能有一致的看法，人们可以很清楚地说明同时有某些特征（找一个非常大的集合，把凡是古典帝国可能出现的特征全部添加于其中）的政权一定是古典国家，并指出完全不具有这些特征的国家一定不能算古典国家，可是对于具有部分这样特征的国家应该如何分类总归是难以达成共识。

所以我的意见是，虽然商业贸易这个修正项的确必要，但是除非不得不引入它进行解释就不将它视为一个重要原因。我这样说还有一个考虑便是，商业和贸易因素确实可以向时间的两个方向延长古典社会，但这不足以使古典时期的历史定位发生本质变化。对于早早进入古典社会的地区而言，在古典时期停留太久并不能给当地带来持续可观的社会进步，甚至像波斯所表现的一样陷入了某种停滞，最终反而成为相对落后的一方。对于在封建化时代仍然延续古典社会的地区而言，看似在碎片化的封建政权中鹤立鸡群的老大帝国也不能够真正越过封建阶段而步入近现代社会，古典帝国的成就确实令人向往，但是对于近现代文明的产生具有决定意义的因素终究要经历封建社会才能出现，拜占庭在历史充分证明了这点。在机遇合适的情况下，即使是非常快速的古典社会也足以实现成功的体制过渡，并向国家引向近代化，日本就是这样的例子。所以无论商业和贸易在何种程度上延伸了古典时期，但是古典社会以“过渡”为核心的特征不会因其改变，古典时期再长作用也是有限的，无法取代封建社会的历史地位。